

» HOCKEY INDIA LEAGUE
WOMEN



Victory at last: The Odisha Warriors won the inaugural Women's Hockey India League 2024-25 by defeating Soorma HC 2-1 in the final. SHASHISHEKAR KASHYAP

A BOLD START WITH ROOM TO GROW

The inaugural Women's Hockey India League overcame challenges to deliver **thrilling matches** and strong fan engagement, marking a promising start.

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The inaugural edition of the Women's Hockey India League (HIL-W) can be best compared to that one terrifying ride at a theme park. You break out in a cold sweat and call out to all your gods the moment you are strapped in, but once it winds up, you're somehow left

craving more.

The build-up to what is currently the only commercial hockey league for women across the globe wasn't particularly encouraging. Conducted under the auspices of Hockey India, the tournament saw several key pullouts by foreign players ahead of the season. With a total purse of Rs 2 crore per team and the highest base-price slab of Rs10 lakh, underbids at the auction were largely

to blame for this.

Moreover, a legal issue led to the deferral of two additional teams — Hyderabad Toofans and a Mumbai-based franchise by BC Jindal Group — until the next season. Rumours suggested that another corporate group was on the verge of reneging on its promises just before the season, but the issue was addressed in time.

However, once the floodlights